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OBA 08

Case Study

1. What factors made Sony Pictures vulnerable to such a large-scale cyberattack, and how did the attackers exploit these weaknesses?

    - Sony Pictures became vulnerable because attackers were able to gain access to its internal network and steal confidential information. The incident also showed the serious consequences of insufficient protection against destructive malware and unauthorized access. The attackers used malware to delete data and make thousands of computers inoperable. They also stole sensitive information, including employees' personal details, private emails, and unreleased movies, which were later leaked online. These actions disrupted Sony's business operations and damaged its reputation.

2. How did geopolitical motivations influence the nature and scale of the Sony hack compared to typical financially driven cyberattacks?

    - The Sony Pictures hack was different from typical financially motivated cyberattacks because its main objective was believed to be political intimidation rather than simply earning money. The attack was linked to the release of The Interview, a comedy film depicting a fictional assassination plot against North Korean leader Kim Jong-un. The FBI attributed the attack to North Korea, citing similarities between the malware and tools associated with previous North Korean cyber activities. The attackers not only stole information but also destroyed computer data, leaked confidential emails, and threatened theaters that planned to show the film. Unlike attacks primarily designed to steal money or financial information, this incident aimed to pressure Sony into changing its business decisions. It demonstrated how cyberattacks can be used as tools of political influence and intimidation.

3. What key lessons from the Sony breach can organizations apply today to strengthen their cybersecurity defenses and incident response plans?

    - Organizations can learn several important lessons from the Sony Pictures cyberattack. First, they should strengthen access controls by using strong passwords, multifactor authentication (MFA), and limiting access to sensitive information to authorized personnel only. Second, organizations should regularly update their software, monitor network activities, and use security tools to detect suspicious behavior. Third, they should maintain secure, offline backups and test their recovery procedures to prevent permanent data loss. Lastly, organizations should prepare an incident response plan that explains how to isolate affected systems, report incidents, communicate with employees and stakeholders, and restore normal operations. The Sony incident demonstrates that cybersecurity requires continuous monitoring, preparation, and cooperation with law enforcement to minimize damage and protect sensitive information.

References

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